balls fell scattershot all around him, in a hail of dust and screams and blood. He took aim at the besieged soldiers using a musket, much improved since the crude brass contraptions used by Babur's men. Akbar's muskets were sophisticated weapons made of iron or steel, designed for accuracy, and he tested every musket in his arsenal himself. He kept 101 muskets within the harem and, in times of peace, he tested each one, in rotation. Mughal matchlocks were able to pack more gunpowder than their European counterparts and were considerably deadlier. Now Akbar gave orders for work on the sabats to continue, and by end February 1568, four bruising months after the siege began, in a final superhuman effort by the Mughal soldiers, the sabats were completed. The Mughal army now attacked the pounded walls of Chittor and Akbar got out his favourite musket, Sangram, and shot at a Rajput officer 'with a spiked breastplate who looked like a commander'. Jaimal, it was later learnt, had been killed and now, desolation in their heart, no more Rajput soldiers advanced to shore up the breaches in the fort walls. As the Mughal officers looked on at the suddenly quiet walls of the fortress, they saw three ominous plumes of smoke drifting up into the cold January evening. 'This is the fire of jauhar,' explained Raja Bhagwant Das to Akbar, telling him of the custom that the Rajputs had of having their women immolate themselves when they faced certain defeat. Three hundred women died in three separate pyres that night—one for the Sisodiya clan, one for the Rathores, and one for the Chauhans.

At first light, the following day, the Mughal troops, some 5,000 men, stormed the breach, followed by their war elephants in full armour, swords strapped to trunks and tusks. The elephants also had steel plates on their brows, to use as battering rams. Some had yak tails and animal pelts attached to them making them appear even more terrifying. Akbar, sitting on the largest elephant of all, joined the attack shouting his new war cry 'Ya Muin!'* The elephants raged and trumpeted and threw enemy soldiers into the air with their trunks and slashed at them in a fury. The 8,000 Rajputs fell to a man, either in the narrow winding lanes of Chittor, crushed by the elephants, or in combat with the Mughal troops, at the rana's haveli or in front of the Mahadeva temple. In addition, some 30,000 civilians who had 'fought fiercely' to defend their fortress were also put to the sword while more were taken captive. The expert snipers, some 1,000 marksmen, who had caused havoc and ruin in the Mughal troops, managed a most daring escape, though Akbar sought them out particularly. Tying up their women